

RELIGIOUS PLURALISM AND THE PROBLEM OF ABSOLUTE TRUTH

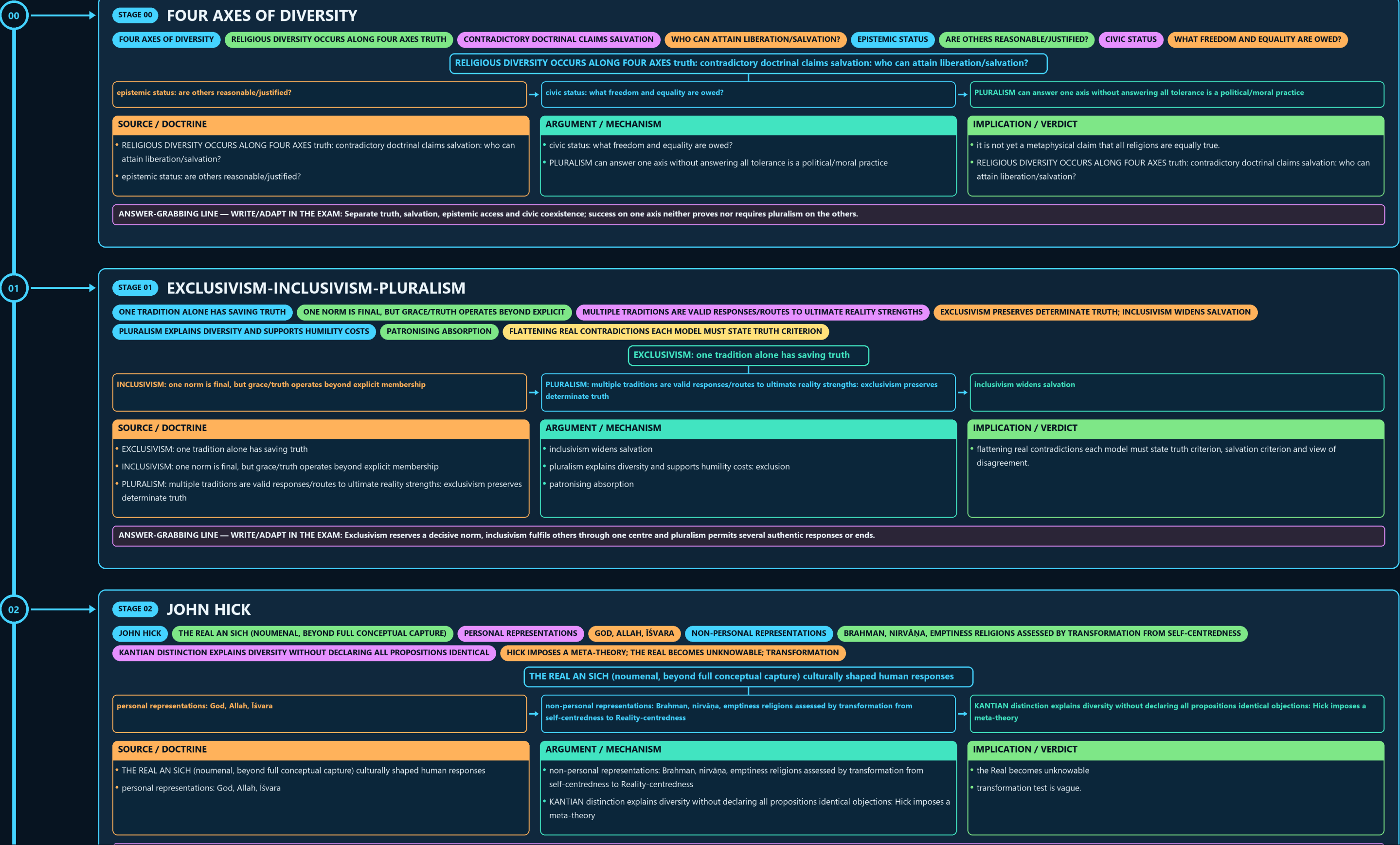
FOUR AXES OF DIVERSITY → EXCLUSIVISM-INCLUSIVISM-PLURALISM → JOHN HICK → VEDĀNTIC MODELS → JAIN MANY-SIDEDNESS → TOLERANCE AND RELIGIOUS FREEDOM

Read the thick cyan rail from Stage 00 to the final core synthesis. Each card uses a concept-appropriate structure; the grey E card is optional enrichment only and never repairs missing core content.

PRIMARY CORE FLOW SUBORDINATE EXTRA APPROVAL / REVIEW

Approval: FALSE • Pending user review • source generation g13 and all prior artifacts unchanged

CORE BEFORE EXTRA • prior artefacts unchanged • exact same master drives poster and tiles



03

SOURCE / DOCTRINE

- THE REAL AN SIC (noumenal, beyond full conceptual capture) culturally shaped human responses
- personal representations: God, Allah, Īsvara

self-centredness to Reality-centredness

- non-personal representations: Brahman, nirvāṇa, emptiness religions assessed by transformation from self-centredness to Reality-centredness
- KANTIAN distinction explains diversity without declaring all propositions identical objections: Hick imposes a meta-theory

meta-theory

- the Real becomes unknowable
- transformation test is vague.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Hick's Real explains conditioned manifestations, but noumenal unknowability, self-reference and identity-redescription pressure the meta-theory.

03

STAGE 03VEDĀNTIC MODELS

VEDĀNTIC MODELS

ONE BRAHMAN; DIFFERENCES BELONG TO EMPIRICAL STANDPOINT

MANY PATHS MAY PREPARE FOR NON-DUAL KNOWLEDGE

REAL PLURALITY WITHIN BRAHMAN'S UNITY; DEVOTION TO PERSONAL GOD

DIVERSE RELIGIOUS PATHS CAN REALISE ONE ULTIMATE

ABSOLUTE-TRUTH PROBLEM IF ALL VIEWS ARE PARTIAL, IS "ALL

REPLY REQUIRES STANDPOINT DISCIPLINE, NOT EFFORTLESS EQUIVALENCE OF INCOMPATIBLE

SYSTEM / DOCTRINE	DECISIVE DISTINCTION	EVALUATION / TRAP
ADVAITA: one Brahman; differences belong to empirical standpoint	RĀMĀNUJA: real plurality within Brahman's unity; devotion to personal God remains final	ABSOLUTE-TRUTH PROBLEM if all views are partial, is "all are partial" itself absolute?
many paths may prepare for non-dual knowledge	RĀMAKRṢṢNA/VIVEKĀNANDA: diverse religious paths can realise one ultimate	reply requires standpoint discipline, not effortless equivalence of incompatible claims.

SYSTEM / DOCTRINE

- ADVAITA: one Brahman; differences belong to empirical standpoint
- many paths may prepare for non-dual knowledge

DECISIVE DISTINCTION

- RĀMĀNUJA: real plurality within Brahman's unity; devotion to personal God remains final
- RĀMAKRṢṢNA/VIVEKĀNANDA: diverse religious paths can realise one ultimate

EVALUATION / TRAP

- ABSOLUTE-TRUTH PROBLEM if all views are partial, is "all are partial" itself absolute?
- reply requires standpoint discipline, not effortless equivalence of incompatible claims.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Vivekananda and Vedanta support convergence and acceptance, but one neo-Vedantic framework must not erase distinct doctrines or ends.

04

STAGE 04JAIN MANY-SIDEDNESS

JAIN MANY-SIDEDNESS

REALITY HAS MANY ASPECTS

EACH FINITE STATEMENT ARISES FROM A STANDPOINT

PREDICATE CONDITIONALLY — IN A CERTAIN RESPECT PLURALIST USE

RIVAL RELIGIONS MAY DISCLOSE DIFFERENT ASPECTS WITHOUT EXHAUSTIVE POSSESSION

EPISTEMIC HUMILITY + NON-VIOLENCE IN JUDGEMENT LIMIT

CONTRADICTIONS ARE RECONCILED ONLY IF RESPECTS GENUINELY DIFFER

SYĀDVĀDA CANNOT SIMPLY PRONOUNCE EVERY DOCTRINE TRUE IN THE

ANEKĀNTAVĀDA: reality has many aspects

NAYAVĀDA: each finite statement arises from a standpoint

SYĀDVĀDA: predicate conditionally — in a certain respect pluralist use; rival religions may disclose different

possession strength: epistemic humility + non-violence in judgement limit: contradictions are reconciled only if respects

SOURCE / DOCTRINE	ARGUMENT / MECHANISM	IMPLICATION / VERDICT
- ANEKĀNTAVĀDA: reality has many aspects - NAYAVĀDA: each finite statement arises from a standpoint	- SYĀDVĀDA: predicate conditionally — in a certain respect pluralist use; rival religions may disclose different aspects without exhaustive - possession strength: epistemic humility + non-violence in judgement limit: contradictions are reconciled only if respects genuinely differ	- syādvāda cannot simply pronounce every doctrine true in the same sense. - ANEKĀNTAVĀDA: reality has many aspects

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Jain many-sidedness qualifies assertions by standpoint and supports humility without making contradictions true in the same respect.

05

STAGE 05TOLERANCE AND RELIGIOUS FREEDOM

TOLERANCE AND RELIGIOUS FREEDOM

REFRAIN FROM COERCION DESPITE DISAGREEMENT RESPECT

RECOGNISE EQUAL STANDING

RECIPROCAL REASON-GIVING FREEDOM

BELIEF, PRACTICE, CHANGE OF RELIGION, NON-BELIEF, ASSOCIATION

LIMITS COERCION

HARM TO RIGHTS MAY BE REGULATED BUT OFFENCE OR

dialogue: reciprocal reason-giving freedom: belief, practice, change of religion, non-belief, association

TOLERANCE: refrain from coercion despite disagreement respect: recognise equal standing

LIMITS coercion

harm to rights may be regulated but offence or theological falsity alone is not sufficient

SOURCE / DOCTRINE	ARGUMENT / MECHANISM	IMPLICATION / VERDICT
- TOLERANCE: refrain from coercion despite disagreement respect: recognise equal standing - dialogue: reciprocal reason-giving freedom: belief, practice, change of religion, non-belief, association	- LIMITS coercion - harm to rights may be regulated but offence or theological falsity alone is not sufficient ground for suppression	- principled pluralism protects persons and conscience, not every practice from criticism. - TOLERANCE: refrain from coercion despite disagreement respect: recognise equal standing

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Tolerance and freedom secure equal civic standing under disagreement: they do not prove equal religious truth or salvation.

RELIGIOUS PLURALISM AND THE PROBLEM OF ABSOLUTE TRUTH • TILE 2/3 • same master rows 2797-6031 of 8828 • continues below

dialogue: reciprocal reason-giving freedom: belief, practice, change of religion, non-belief, association

LIMITS coercion

harm to rights may be regulated but offence or theological falsity alone is not sufficient

SOURCE / DOCTRINE

- TOLERANCE: refrain from coercion despite disagreement respect: recognise equal standing
- dialogue: reciprocal reason-giving freedom: belief, practice, change of religion, non-belief, association

ARGUMENT / MECHANISM

- LIMITS coercion
- harm to rights may be regulated but offence or theological falsity alone is not sufficient ground for suppression

IMPLICATION / VERDICT

- principled pluralism protects persons and conscience, not every practice from criticism.
- TOLERANCE: refrain from coercion despite disagreement respect: recognise equal standing

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Tolerance and freedom secure equal civic standing under disagreement; they do not prove equal religious truth or salvation.

06

STAGE 06

CONFLICT, UNIFICATION AND DEEP DISAGREEMENT

CONFLICT, UNIFICATION AND DEEP DISAGREEMENT

CONFLICT SOURCES

EXCLUSIVE REVELATION

SACRED HISTORY

GRIEVANCE RESPONSES

COMMON ETHICAL CORE

COMPARATIVE THEOLOGY

LEGAL NEUTRALITY

CONFLICT SOURCES: exclusive revelation

sacred history

grievance responses: syncretism

common ethical core

SOURCE / DOCTRINE

- CONFLICT SOURCES: exclusive revelation
- sacred history
- grievance responses: syncretism

ARGUMENT / MECHANISM

- common ethical core
- comparative theology
- legal neutrality

IMPLICATION / VERDICT

- DEEP DISAGREEMENT persists because standards of evidence are tradition-shaped humility != relativism: give reasons, admit fallibility, seek overlap,
- preserve dissent objections to pluralism: self-refuting, imperial meta-theory, doctrinal dilution reply: modest pluralism can defend equal civic respect
- without equalising every truth claim.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — DEEP DISAGREEMENT persists because standards of evidence are tradition-shaped humility != relativism: give reasons, admit fallibility, seek overlap, preserve dissent objections to pluralism: self-refuting, imperial meta-theory, doctrinal dilution reply: modest pluralism can defend equal civic respect without equalising every truth claim.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Deep disagreement explains persistent divergence and makes dialogue, fallibilism and explicit frameworks rational duties rather than proof of relativism.

07

STAGE 07

PYQ ANSWER SPINE

PYQ ANSWER SPINE

DEFINE AXIS

MAP EXCLUSIVISM/INCLUSIVISM/PLURALISM

EXPLAIN HICK EXACTLY

COMPARE ADVAITA/RĀMĀNUJA/JAIN ANEKĀNTA

TEST ABSOLUTE-TRUTH OBJECTION

MOVE FROM METAPHYSICAL DIVERSITY TO TOLERANCE/FREEDOM WITH LIMITS

QUALIFIED CONCLUSION

DEFINE axis → map exclusivism/inclusivism/pluralism → explain Hick exactly

compare Advaita/Rāmānuja/Jain anekānta → test absolute-truth objection

move from metaphysical diversity to tolerance/freedom with limits

qualified conclusion

CLOSE: defensible pluralism is neither “all religions say the same” nor relativism

SOURCE / DOCTRINE

- DEFINE axis → map exclusivism/inclusivism/pluralism → explain Hick exactly
- compare Advaita/Rāmānuja/Jain anekānta → test absolute-truth objection

ARGUMENT / MECHANISM

- move from metaphysical diversity to tolerance/freedom with limits
- qualified conclusion

IMPLICATION / VERDICT

- CLOSE: defensible pluralism is neither “all religions say the same” nor relativism
- it combines truth-seeking, fallibilism, transformative comparison and equal civic liberty.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Defensible pluralism preserves truth constraints, acknowledges hard contradictions and separates metaphysical theory from civic respect.

E

EXTRA

SUBORDINATE ENRICHMENT — ONLY AFTER THE COMPLETE CORE

OPTIONAL ADVANCED ENRICHMENT

ADVANCED-DOSSIER RECONCILIATION — [OPTIONAL ADVANCED]

DOCTRINE STATEMENT.

EXCLUSIVISM MAKES ONE TRADITION'S DECISIVE TRUTH/SALVATION CLAIM UNIQUELY VALID

INCLUSIVISM GRANTS TRUTH OR SALVATION BEYOND IT WHILE INTERPRETING

EXCLUSIVISM APPEALS TO DETERMINATE REVELATION AND NON-CONTRADICTION.

INCLUSIVISM ADDS UNIVERSALITY OF DIVINE GRACE WHILE PRESERVING NORMATIVE

PRESUPPOSITION. CAUTION

OPTIONAL SOURCE WITNESS

- Advanced-dossier reconciliation — [OPTIONAL ADVANCED]
- Doctrine statement.
- Exclusivism makes one tradition's decisive truth/salvation claim uniquely valid
- inclusivism grants truth or salvation beyond it while interpreting that success through the home tradition.

ADVANCED OBJECTION

- Argument.
- Exclusivism appeals to determinate revelation and non-contradiction.
- Inclusivism adds universality of divine grace while preserving normative priority.
- Presupposition. CAUTION: One revelation has privileged warrant, and salvation can be specified independently enough to compare traditions.

COMPARATIVE NUANCE

- Distinction. Inclusivism is not pluralism: others are included on terms set by the privileged tradition.
- Canonical example. Rahner's "anonymous Christian" is a standard inclusivist model.
- Objection → reply.
- CAUTION: Inclusivism appears patronising.

OPTIONAL STATUS — This optional depth is unnecessary for a competent core answer; use it only for added nuance after the complete core has been written.